

“South tax devolution debate is politically motivated”

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, after presenting the Interim Budget, talks about optimism in the economy, household savings, and more

PHOTOS BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

48 |

N

Nirmala Sitharaman has helmed the finance portfolio in the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government for the past five years. In her current term as Finance Minister, she has had to deal with a pandemic, global slowdown and more. And in an election year, she chose to shun populism in the Interim Budget. In an exclusive interview with *Rahul Kanwal*, News Director of India Today and Aaj Tak, and Executive director of *Business Today*, and BTTV Managing Editor *Siddharth Zarabi*, she talks about the economy, growth, and secularism, among other things. Edited excerpts:

RAHUL KANWAL: When you do a temperature check of the Indian economy, what is it that gives you the greatest optimism, and what is it that’s making you the most concerned?

A: The optimism bit is because of the power of word of mouth. People who have benefitted from the government’s promises are speaking about it themselves. And they are [from] across the board... And that gives trust in people’s minds... when people say yes, I’ve got a house, I’ve got a gas connection, water has come to my tap, and my sons or daughters are getting skills, they are getting recruited... So that power of the word of mouth, among beneficiaries or potential beneficiaries, is the one that makes me feel that people realise that this is a government that promises and delivers, and the PM is seized of everything that is happening on the ground. That is one. The other confidence [is that] try as they may, the opposition in their ruled states have not matched this kind of performance. And to top it all, not one scandal in 10 years. The image of India—fragile five, policy paralysis, corruption at every level—has changed in 10 years.

The challenges and worries are more external... wars abroad, uncertainty in the Red Sea, marine lines getting affected, supply chain disruptions. I think in the last three to four years, uncertainties have become the rule of the game. We have to live with them.

SIDDHARTH ZARABI: What is the need for a white paper on the state of the economy that the government inherited? And why now?

A: The PM himself had spoken about it in 2015 or 2016. He said then that there were a lot of people suggesting to him that he come out with a white paper. And he chose not to do it then. And he explained the reasons... He said, ‘I’ll put my nation first. I don’t want to come up with a white paper which is going to reveal all that was left for us to inherit. And that will only affect